

SOP-LADR-1700: Portable Ladder Safety

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Section 1. Purpose and Scope

Governs selection, inspection, and use of portable ladders (step and extension).

Section 2. Selection

Clause 2.1 — Ladder duty rating shall exceed the combined weight of the user, tools, and materials carried; Type IA (300 lb) or heavier is required for industrial use, not consumer-grade Type III.

Clause 2.2 — Conductive (aluminum) ladders are prohibited within 10 feet of exposed energized electrical equipment; fiberglass ladders are required in those areas.

Section 3. Inspection

Clause 3.1 — Ladders shall be visually inspected before each use for cracked rails, missing rubber feet, or bent rungs; a defective ladder shall be tagged out of service immediately, not merely avoided by the finder.

Section 4. Setup and Angle

Clause 4.1 — Extension ladder setup angle shall follow the 4-to-1 rule (1 foot of base offset for every 4 feet of working height); the ladder shall extend at least 3 feet above the landing point when used for roof/platform access.

Section 5. Use Restrictions

Clause 5.1 — The top two rungs of a step ladder and the top three rungs of an extension ladder are not standing surfaces.

Clause 5.2 — Three points of contact shall be maintained at all times; carrying items in both hands while climbing is prohibited — use a tool belt or hoist line instead.

Section 6. Records

Clause 6.1 — Ladder inspection tags are maintained at the equipment; ladders failing inspection are removed from the equipment pool and logged in the Safety Department File.